Minimum MEAL Package and maturity baseline

Paper MEC-09, policy P1 of 7, for decision

Friday 20 November 2026, Session 3, 10:45–11:45 | Block A. Performance and evidence | For decision

Draft of 4 November 2026 for TWG review. Parameters such as deadlines, response times and thresholds not set by the Framework are proposals, shown as such in the decision options.

The policy in brief

Every Country Office reaches and keeps the Minimum MEAL Package floor, establishes its maturity baseline through a Learning Lab by June 2028 and turns it into a costed Country MEAL Development Plan endorsed by the WR.

Why this policy

The Minimum MEAL Package is the floor below which a Country Office cannot credibly claim that evidence informs its decisions. The Framework sets the floor at Level 3 (Developing) and builds every other instrument on it: the Country MEAL Development Plan closes gaps to the floor first, the heat map shows where support is needed, and the re-assessment tracks progress.

None of this works until each office knows where it stands. Today the Region has a measured baseline for four pilot offices only, so support cannot be targeted and development plans have no diagnosis to start from.

What the evidence shows

- A measured MEAL maturity baseline exists in **4 of 47** Country Offices (Performance Intelligence pilots, 2026; paper MEC-08).
- Two floor disciplines are not yet visible in SAM1 2026: **1 of 1,336** P/S assessments cites an evidence source (Domain 5), and the decision log records no verification of completion, with **91 of 970** entries overdue at export (Domain 8).

Scope

The 47 Country Offices. The six Regional Office budget centres complete the Annex C self-assessment for their own operations in 2027.

The policy

1. **The Minimum MEAL Package is mandatory.** Every Country Office reaches at least Level 3 (Developing) against the minimum requirements of Annex C, the master reference for all twelve domains, starting with the seven essential domains summarized in Part VII.1, and keeps it. The 3% financing requirement (Domain 3) is the gateway: an office below it does not meet the Package, whatever its other results (see P3).
2. **Self-assessment by 31 March 2027.** Each office completes the Annex C self-assessment checklist, with the evidence for each requirement. MSC consolidates the results into a first regional view of the floor and uses it to schedule the Learning Labs.
3. **A maturity baseline in three waves.** Each office establishes its baseline against the four pillars, twelve domains and 48 sub-dimensions (Annex A) through a facilitated Learning Lab: wave 1 from January to June 2027, wave 2 from July to December 2027 and wave 3 from January to June 2028. MSC sets the order with the clusters, starting with offices whose self-assessment shows the largest gaps and offices preparing a new CCS. The four pilot offices confirm their 2026 baseline against the final scale in wave 1.
4. **Scores rest on evidence.** Offices score themselves against the descriptors of Annex D and MSC validates the scores for consistency across offices. A level is awarded only when its criteria are met and supported by verifiable evidence; where evidence is ambiguous, the lower level applies. Documentary evidence alone never meets a requirement (Annex C, Section C5).

5. **A development plan within eight weeks.** Within eight weeks of its validated baseline, each office prepares its Country MEAL Development Plan on the Annex B template: priority gaps, root causes, target levels, actions, owners, costs and funding sources. Closing gaps to the floor comes before any other improvement. The WR endorses the plan as a resource commitment; MSC validates it for the Region as a commitment to support (Annex B, Template Section 10).
6. **The plan lives in the workplan.** Each office enters the actions that close the gaps found in its self-assessment in its 2028–2029 workplan. The full development plan enters the SPM and the workplan once endorsed: at workplan preparation for offices assessed in wave 1, and at the first workplan revision of 2028 for waves 2 and 3. Progress is reviewed monthly in the WR-led review, against milestones each quarter, alongside each SAM cycle and in full once a year (Annex B, Section B9).
7. **Annual check, re-assessment every two years.** Package status is reviewed each year in step with the SAM cycle (Annex C, Section C11). The full maturity assessment is repeated two years after the baseline.
8. **Results direct support.** Validated scores feed the Regional Maturity Heat Map, which targets support and is never used to rank offices. An office below the floor receives targeted support and an accelerated plan.

Who does what

WHO Representative	Accountable for reaching and keeping the floor; endorses the development plan and chairs its monthly review.
MEAL focal point	Leads the self-assessment, assembles the evidence and coordinates the plan and its tracking.
Programme leads	Meet the floor in their areas, in particular P/S monitoring and decision follow-up.
MSC Unit	Schedules the waves, facilitates Learning Labs, validates scores and development plans, maintains the heat map and reports to the DPM and the MEC.
Regional Office clusters	Provide the support committed in validated plans; join Learning Labs in their technical areas.

Timeline

When	Milestone
20 Nov 2026	Policy adopted by the MEC
31 Mar 2027	Annex C self-assessment completed by all 47 Country Offices
Jan–Jun 2027	Wave 1 Learning Labs, including the four pilot offices
Jul–Dec 2027	Wave 2 Learning Labs; first heat map at MEC 2027
Jan–Jun 2028	Wave 3 Learning Labs; all baselines validated
31 Aug 2028	All 47 development plans endorsed and in the workplans

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices with a validated maturity baseline	4 of 47 pilots, to be confirmed in wave 1	47 by 30 June 2028
Country Offices with a WR-endorsed development plan in the workplan	Not yet measured	47 by 31 August 2028
Country Offices meeting the floor in every domain	First, unvalidated reading from the 2027 self-assessment	Rising at each annual review; target set by MEC 2028 from the validated baselines

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Mandatory for all Country Offices in three waves, with the self-assessment by March 2027**	Every office has a validated baseline and plan by mid-2028, at a pace MSC and the facilitator pool can sustain.
B	Mandatory in two waves, with all baselines by December 2027	All plans endorsed by early 2028, a few months sooner; facilitation needs roughly double in 2027.
C	Self-assessment only; Learning Labs on request	Lowest cost, but no validated baseline, no reliable heat map and development plans without a diagnosis.

Resources

Learning Lab facilitation, travel and the platform modules for the assessment and development plan. Costed in paper MEC-10.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the Minimum MEAL Package as the mandatory floor for all Country Offices and the three-wave baseline schedule (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts VII, VIII and XIII; Annexes A, B, C and D; Annex G, Modules 5, 6 and 12. Domains: All twelve domains at the floor (Annex C), strengthened in the Framework's order of priority (Part XIV.2).